

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Law English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For lawyers, paralegals, compliance staff, contracts specialists, legal operations teams, and law-adjacent professionals.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Legal English Mindset: Facts, Issues, Rules, Risk

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

02 Client Intake, Scope, Conflicts, and Confidentiality

Clarify missing information before responding.

03 Litigation Lifecycle: Pleadings, Motions, Deadlines, Strategy

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

04 Discovery, ESI, Privilege Review, and Depositions

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

05 Legal Research, Authority, and Memo Writing

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

06 Contracts, Redlines, and Negotiation

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

07 Corporate, Compliance, Regulatory, and Investigation Language

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

08 Advocacy, Settlement, Ethics, and Professional Judgment

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Legal English Mindset: Facts, Issues, Rules, Risk

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

An internal case note says a supplier "breached the contract." The team has the delivery email but has not reviewed the signed agreement.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: Jurisdiction, Materiality, Allege, Assert.

Model response

The delivery email records a delay. Whether that amounts to a breach requires review of the agreement and relevant law. I'll separate the documented facts from the legal questions in the note.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. An email is not the signed agreement - The lesson's internal team has a delivery email but has not reviewed the signed supplier agreement. This is language practice, not legal advice.

2. A witness reports a conversation - Separate fictional training case: a witness reports that a manager promised a refund; no recording or written confirmation is available.

3. A missing attachment and a materiality claim - Separate fictional training case: an internal file lacks a contract attachment, but no one has established whether the signed original included it.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A draft labeled final

A fictional case folder contains a document named Final Agreement, but its signature fields are blank. No executed version has been located. A colleague wants to call its terms binding.

Role A: You are the case assistant. Explain what the file shows without drawing a legal conclusion.

Role B: You supervise the review. Ask what version evidence is missing and identify the next review step.

Possible opening: The filename says final, but this copy has blank signature fields and no executed version is available.

Success checks

- Separate the filename from execution evidence.
- Avoid deciding enforceability from the supplied facts.
- Agree to seek version evidence and qualified review.

Add a complication: The colleague argues that the filename alone proves acceptance.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Client Intake, Scope, Conflicts, and Confidentiality

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A prospective client sends a long description of a dispute and asks for immediate advice. The intake team has not completed its conflict check.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: Conflict of interest, Confidentiality, Engagement letter, Scope of representation.

Model response

Before we discuss advice, could you provide the names of the parties and the type of assistance you are seeking? Our team needs to complete intake and confirm the scope of any engagement.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. C - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Clarifying intake before substantive advice - The lesson's prospective client has sent a dispute account; the conflict check is incomplete. No representation is assumed.

2. Which company is seeking representation? - Separate fictional intake: a director contacts a firm about a dispute involving two related companies; the intended client is unclear.

3. A new issue outside the stated assignment - Separate fictional training case: an existing engagement covers reviewing a lease draft; a client now asks about an unrelated employment dispute.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A referral without a confirmed client

A fictional consultant introduces a business owner to a firm and asks to join the intake call. The owner has not said whether they want the consultant present, and no engagement is established.

Role A: You coordinate intake. Clarify the owner's preference and the consultant's proposed role before discussing substance.

Role B: You are the business owner. State that the consultant made the introduction but their continuing involvement is undecided.

Possible opening: Before discussing the matter, could we clarify who you want present and in what role?

Success checks

- Separate referral from authorization to participate.
- Keep representation and information-sharing arrangements unconfirmed.
- Agree who will clarify participation before substantive discussion.

Add a complication: The consultant assumes making the referral gives them access to all subsequent discussions.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Litigation Lifecycle: Pleadings, Motions, Deadlines, Strategy

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A litigation task list has two dates from different documents. The supervising lawyer has not confirmed which deadline controls.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: Complaint, Answer, Motion, Order.

Model response

The task list contains conflicting dates. I have attached both source documents and flagged the issue for your review. Please confirm the controlling deadline before I update the calendar.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. B - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. A - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. Two dates awaiting supervisory review - The lesson's litigation list contains dates from two documents; the supervising lawyer has not confirmed the controlling deadline.

2. Drafted is not filed - Separate fictional litigation exercise: an answer has been drafted and awaits lawyer approval; there is no filing confirmation.

3. A motion discussed but not authorized - Separate fictional litigation exercise: a team discussed a possible motion, but counsel has not decided whether to pursue it.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A hearing request without a confirmed listing

A fictional case record shows that a hearing request was submitted, but no confirmed listing is present. A client asks whether attendance should be arranged for the requested date.

Role A: You are the litigation coordinator. Report the submitted request and pending confirmation separately.

Role B: You are the supervising lawyer. Ask what evidence is available and direct the appropriate status check.

Possible opening: The hearing request was submitted, but the record does not yet confirm a listing.

Success checks

- Distinguish a request from a confirmed listing.
- Avoid inventing an attendance instruction or controlling date.
- Agree a status check with the responsible professional.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to treat the requested date as the confirmed hearing date.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Discovery, ESI, Privilege Review, and Depositions

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A document reviewer finds an email chain that may contain privileged communications. It is in a review set, not yet a production set.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: Discovery, Deposition, Privilege, Work product.

Model response

Please review this email chain for potential privilege before a production decision. I've identified the participants and relevant messages. I have not made a final privilege determination.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. A - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. C - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Requesting review of a potentially privileged chain - The lesson's email chain is in a review set, not a production set, and privilege is unconfirmed.

2. Requesting a missing attachment for discovery review - Separate fictional discovery exercise: a review email refers to an attachment absent from the collected set; its contents are unknown.

3. Preparing deposition materials without assuming disclosure - Separate fictional litigation exercise: counsel requests a proposed deposition bundle; some selected documents have unresolved review flags.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A transcript passage needs a source check

A fictional deposition summary contains a quotation attributed to page twelve, but the available transcript excerpt ends at page ten. No one has checked the complete transcript.

Role A: You are the reviewing lawyer. Request the complete source or a verified passage before relying on the quotation.

Role B: You are the case assistant. Explain the excerpt's limit and arrange the source check without inventing the missing words.

Possible opening: Could you locate the complete transcript so we can verify the quotation attributed to page twelve?

Success checks

- State the page-ten limit accurately.
- Do not treat plausibility as verification.
- Agree a source check before reliance on the quotation.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests retaining the quotation because it sounds consistent with earlier testimony.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Legal Research, Authority, and Memo Writing

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A draft memo cites one decision as controlling authority. The case came from another jurisdiction and the research is still preliminary.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: Binding authority, Persuasive authority, Precedent, Distinguish.

Model response

This decision may help the analysis, but we should not label it binding without checking its authority in the relevant jurisdiction. I'll explain that distinction and identify what further research is needed.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. B - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Persuasive does not mean controlling - The lesson's preliminary memo cites a decision from another jurisdiction as controlling; its authority has not been established.

2. A similar outcome with different facts - Separate fictional research exercise: a located decision reaches a favorable outcome, but its facts differ from the client's account.

3. A headnote is not the court's full reasoning - Separate fictional research exercise: an assistant has read a case summary but not the full judgment or its subsequent treatment.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two sources with different purposes

A fictional research file contains a commentary article and a court decision discussing the same issue. Neither source's applicability to the matter has been assessed.

Role A: You supervise research. Explain why commentary and a decision serve different research roles.

Role B: You are the research assistant. Paraphrase the distinction and ask what authority and relevance checks remain.

Possible opening: The article may help explain the issue, but it is not interchangeable with the court's decision.

Success checks

- Distinguish explanation from judicial authority.
- Keep applicability unresolved for both sources.
- Agree to examine the decision and its authority before characterizing it.

Add a complication: The article is easier to read, and a colleague proposes citing it as controlling authority.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Contracts, Redlines, and Negotiation

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A draft services agreement requires delivery within ten days. The commercial team needs fifteen days and wants the contract team to propose wording.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: Representation, Warranty, Indemnity, Limitation of liability.

Model response

Our delivery team can commit to fifteen days under the current scope. Could we revise the proposed period accordingly? I'll send the business rationale for legal review with the redline.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. B - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. A - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

05 · Conversations

1. Proposing fifteen days without announcing agreement - The lesson's services draft says ten days; the commercial team needs fifteen. Wording remains subject to legal and counterparty review.
2. Scope reduction instead of an unsupported warranty - Separate fictional contract negotiation: a customer requests support for all equipment, while the supplier's proposal covers one named product line.

3. A liability request needs coordinated review - Separate fictional contract exercise: procurement requests a broader indemnity while the draft's limitation-of-liability section is still under review.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A milestone definition is missing

A fictional draft ties payment to completion of training, but the parties have not agreed whether completion means delivering the session or participants passing an assessment. No payment change is approved.

Role A: You represent the supplier's commercial team. Clarify the two meanings and propose a reviewable definition.

Role B: You coordinate contract review for the customer. State which interpretation needs internal confirmation.

Possible opening: Before we negotiate the payment milestone, could we clarify what completion of training means here?

Success checks

- Name both interpretations.
- Keep the payment obligation and definition unagreed.
- Agree an internal review step before making a conditional proposal.

Add a complication: A participant asks you to promise payment on delivery while the definition is still unresolved.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Corporate, Compliance, Regulatory, and Investigation Language

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

An employee interview contains a report of possible misconduct. A manager asks to describe the allegation as a confirmed violation in a summary.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: Due diligence, Disclosure, Enforcement action, Remediation.

Model response

At this stage, we have an allegation and an interview record. The finding is not established. I'll use neutral wording and identify the questions that the investigation still needs to resolve.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. An interview allegation is not a confirmed violation - The lesson's interview reports possible misconduct; a manager wants the summary to call it a confirmed violation.

2. A due-diligence gap is not a clean result - Separate fictional transaction review: due diligence received no response to one questionnaire section; no independent check has resolved it.

3. A remediation step without a causal conclusion - Separate fictional compliance exercise: a team added a second review to an expense process after an allegation; the investigation is unfinished.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An inquiry mistaken for enforcement

A fictional organization receives a request for information from a regulator. The supplied record contains no finding, sanction, or enforcement decision. A manager calls it a penalty notice.

Role A: You prepare compliance updates. Describe the received request and correct the unsupported label.

Role B: You are the manager. Ask which facts can be stated and who should assess the response.

Possible opening: The document requests information; the record does not show a penalty or enforcement finding.

Success checks

- Describe the document without either exaggerating or dismissing it.
- Keep its legal significance subject to qualified review.
- Agree the response-review owner rather than inventing a deadline or obligation.

Add a complication: Another colleague wants to call the request routine and harmless, which is also unassessed.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Advocacy, Settlement, Ethics, and Professional Judgment

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

CASE

Two team members disagree about settlement priorities. One prioritizes timing; the other prioritizes confidentiality. Counsel is preparing for a client discussion.

Teach this move

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: Settle, Reserve rights, Stipulate, Object.

Model response

Let's separate the objectives before discussing terms. How important are timing and confidentiality to the client? We can present the options and their implications for the client's instructions.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Second-round challenge

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Language-check answers

1. C - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. B - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

05 • Conversations

1. Timing and confidentiality before client instructions - The lesson's team disagrees on settlement priorities: one values timing, the other confidentiality. Counsel is preparing for a client discussion.
2. Agreeing a chronology without conceding liability - Separate fictional case conference: counsel considers asking the client about agreeing a limited chronology; no stipulation has been authorized.
3. Protecting a dissenting settlement concern - Separate fictional mediation preparation: the commercial lead favors speed, but the operations representative has not discussed implementation feasibility.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 • Say it: second scenario | An enthusiastic response is not acceptance

In fictional settlement preparation, a business representative says an option sounds promising. They have not authorized acceptance, and counsel has not reviewed the proposed wording. Another participant wants to announce a deal.

Role A: You facilitate the discussion. Clarify the difference between interest and instructions to accept.

Role B: You are the business representative. Explain that you want further review and identify the decision still needed.

Possible opening: Promising describes your reaction, but could we clarify whether any acceptance has actually been authorized?

Success checks

- Preserve the absence of acceptance authority.
- Invite the representative's actual instruction.
- Close with review and decision responsibilities clear, not a claimed deal.

Add a complication: A participant says a quick announcement would create useful momentum.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Courts: glossary of legal terms

<https://www.uscourts.gov/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Law English

Professional audience: lawyers, paralegals, compliance staff, contracts specialists, legal operations teams, and law-adjacent professionals

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Legal English Mindset: Facts, Issues, Rules, Risk

Original fictional case: An internal case note says a supplier "breached the contract." The team has the delivery email but has not reviewed the signed agreement.

Language workshop: Match certainty to evidence

Communication goal: Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Language guidance: Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): The available evidence shows ... / This may indicate ..., but ... / We have not yet established whether ...

Vocabulary: Jurisdiction: A court's legal authority to hear a matter or exercise power over a party or subject. / Materiality: Importance of information to a legal, regulatory, investor, or business decision. / Allege: State a claim or fact as asserted but not yet proven. / Assert: State a position, claim, right, defense, or privilege.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The delivery email records a delay. Whether that amounts to a breach requires review of the agreement and relevant law. I'll separate the documented facts from the legal questions in the note.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Law English

Professional audience: lawyers, paralegals, compliance staff, contracts specialists, legal operations teams, and law-adjacent professionals

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Legal English Mindset: Facts, Issues, Rules, Risk

Original fictional case: An internal case note says a supplier "breached the contract." The team has the delivery email but has not reviewed the signed agreement.

Language workshop: Match certainty to evidence

Communication goal: Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Language guidance: Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): The available evidence shows ... / This may indicate ..., but ... / We have not yet established whether ...

Vocabulary: Jurisdiction: A court's legal authority to hear a matter or exercise power over a party or subject. / Materiality: Importance of information to a legal, regulatory, investor, or business decision. / Allege: State a claim or fact as asserted but not yet proven. / Assert: State a position, claim, right, defense, or privilege.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level